Adrian Zhang

Tracks

for small ensemble

(2023)

I was inspired to write "Tracks" by listening to Steve Reich's piece "Eight Lines."

The minimalist style of "Tracks" matches the simple nature of the subject matter—a train—which most people generally do not think about beyond its role in maintaining their daily schedules.

Like a train starting a voyage, the music begins slowly, but as the symbolic train accelerates, the number of instruments featured in the piece also increases. All the instruments increase and decrease in volume together, comparable to how the elements of a train work in unison to accelerate or deccelerate. The music occasionally stops on a chord, which represents the train's stoppages, whether at stations or checkpoints, to allow passengers to enter or exit or to load or unload cargo. The minor variation in notes at the junctions signify the changing kinetics of the train as some people leave, while others stay. Nonetheless, the train itself does not change, so the song's main rhythms remain intact for the first part.

However, during the second part of the piece, the piano rhythms change, which indicates an out-of-the-ordinary occurrence. When the music resolves with a tonal center, consider the issue on the train to be fixed. The first piano rhythm re-emerges for a time but evolves yet again into a slightly different variation of the second piano rhythm, symbolic of a day in the life onboard a train.

And then, as if on cue, the train rolls to a stop.

Duration: around 5 minutes